

port any longer. The machinations and seat-hankering attitude of the Congress leadership at the local level in Bengal led to its marginalisation to the extent that it has barely managed to enter double digit in the poll tally. As part of its pre-poll pact, Banerjee had offered only 25 seats to the Congress which it refused, saying "only around 10 were winnable seats". In the bargain, the party has managed to win just about that number throughout the state.

Banerjee, however, kept all her options open and even as she made it clear that she had had to fight both the CPI(M) and the Congress, and said that her equations with the Centre were

dubbed as "bad politics," Banerjee made no bones about calling off the poll alliance on her terms, skipped Cabinet meetings in the Capital and kept Sonia Gandhi's favourite Land Acquisition Bill pending in Parliament, calling the Congress' bluff as it were. Finally, Banerjee successfully played the Bengal card. The fact that she sees Bengal as being on her priority list more than the job at hand may go down badly with anybody else, but not in her state.

And even as the results started pouring in, she sprang a leak: that she had "learnt" that the Union Home Ministry had ordered a CBI enquiry into the train tragedy days after

result has been significant; even a CPI(M) bastion like Memari in Bardhaman district has gone her way. Not to forget places like Bankura, Purulia and Midnapore where the Trinamool was a no-show earlier.

These major inroads into the rural heartland are the obvious signs that the CPI(M) has given up; without the villages, the party has been left without its primary constituency.

The future waits for Banerjee since it is well nigh impossible for the CPI(M) to recoup. As a masterstroke yet again, shortly after the full results were out, Banerjee was humility personified; no clenching of fists, no sound and fury and no abuses hurled at the CPI(M).

A SMALL STEP BUT A GIANT LEAP		
KOLKATA MUNICIPAL CORPORATION POLL RESULTS		
2005	2010	
Left: 75	Left: 33	
Trinamool: 42	Trinamool: 95	
Congress: 15	Congress: 10	
Others: 9	Others: 3	
	Total Wards: 141	
WEST BENGAL CIVIC POLL RESULTS		
2005	2010	
Left: 54	Left: 18	
Trinamool: 11	Trinamool: 27	
Congress: 16	Congress: 7	
	Hung: 29	
	Total Municipalities: 81	



**CHIEF MINISTER
BUDDHADEB
BHATTACHARYA
COULD DO
LITTLE TO
PREVENT THE
EROSION OF HIS
PARTY'S
SUPPORT BASE
IN BENGAL**

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"always good". Trinamool minister Sougata Roy says, "The Congress has no option but to look inwards. People have made their views clear enough."

But the comforting thought for Bengal is that there is no shrillness in Banerjee's voice. Maybe, it's smugness as her detractors point out, but perhaps it is the satisfaction and confidence that the inevitable is just a prize year away. Mamata's focus on her home state may be drawing criticism from all quarters, but all of it has paid rich dividends to her party as the election results point out. Having had enough of what she

Home Minister P. Chidambaram had said that no CBI probe was needed as long as the state Government wanted it. Suddenly, people in higher places are not cribbing about Banerjee protesting too much; it could well be this spunk without rhetoric which will see her in the chief minister's chair next year.

To her credit, Banerjee did her best in weeding out unwanted elements, something the CPI(M) ought to learn from. She moved in with ruthlessness against some of her sitting councillors, who had their images sullied by charges of various sorts. The

Instead, rhyming couplets from Tagore flowed from her with the confidence-building clarion call: "Bengal can do it." Throughout, she harped on people. On the Jnaneshwari Express tragedy which happened a few days before the elections, she quietly reminded, "I hope people have seen what I did for those who were still alive inside the compartments."

For those in Bengal, who have lived but with muted protests for the last three decades since the CPI(M) rot set in, this could just be a good start and a good beginning.

with Priya Sahgal